

Articles Guide

This lesson guide focuses on a seemingly simple topic: the indefinite articles **a** and **an**. While they may appear straightforward, these two little words can lead to some very common errors, especially when used with uncountable nouns, plural-only items or in set phrases. In the pages that follow, you'll find clear explanations, useful examples and suitable alternatives to help you avoid typical mistakes. I've also included a quiz to help make sure all of the information you've learnt sticks! Whether you're brushing up for fluency or teaching others, this guide will clarify the rules and help you apply them with confidence.

Uncountable Nouns: Food & Drink

Let's begin with our first category. Take a look at this sentence. Consider why it is incorrect to say:

I had **a** toast for breakfast. ✗

What is an uncountable noun?

An **uncountable noun** refers to something that cannot usually be counted individually as it is seen as a whole.

These nouns don't normally have a plural form. Think of things like:

- **Substances:** water, rice, wood
- **Abstract ideas:** advice, information, knowledge
- **General activities:** work, homework, travel

It's because **toast** is an **uncountable noun**. The articles **a** and **an** mean **one**, so we only use them before singular countable nouns, for example:

- "I had **a waffle** and **an orange** for breakfast."

We can't add 's' to pluralise uncountable nouns. We don't say '**toasts**.'

So, how can we correct the sentence above?

- I had **some** toast for breakfast. ✓ ← some + uncountable noun

If you want to be more specific about the quantity, we can make toast countable by adding the words '**slice of**'.

- I had **a slice of** toast for breakfast. ✓

The noun 'slice' is countable, so now we can go ahead and add as many slices as we like:

- I had **two / three / four slices of** toast for breakfast. ✓

It's also common to hear 'a piece of/pieces of', for example:

- I had **3 pieces of** toast for breakfast. ✓

■ Uncountable Nouns: Piece Words

Many food and drink nouns in English are uncountable. Common examples include: **water, milk, rice, sugar, butter, marmalade, salt, bacon, garlic, coffee.**

Because these nouns refer to general substances or masses, we can't use **a** or **an** directly with them. We also can't make them plural in the usual way (we don't say "toasts" or "rices").

To talk about specific amounts, we pair them with "piece words" or units of measurement — words that describe a quantity, container or portion. Here are some useful examples:

Piece Words	Noun
a bottle of	water
a pint of	milk
a jar of	marmalade
a pinch of	salt
a knob of	butter

We typically use the **schwa** /ə/ to pronounce 'a'. We don't generally use the strong forms /eɪ/ or /æ/, unless we need to stress something.

a rasher of	bacon
a clove of	garlic
a bar of	chocolate
a bowl of	cereal
a spoonful of	sugar

These piece words can also be used in the plural:

- 'He ate **three bars of** chocolate.'
- 'Can you add **2 pinches of** salt?'

■ Uncountable Nouns: Common Errors

My students often make mistakes with uncountable nouns. Let's go through a few of the common ones now and iron out those mistakes.

● advice /əd'vaɪs/

We can't say:

- 'I'll give you **an** advice.' ❌

Instead, use **some** with uncountable nouns.

- 'I'll give you **some** advice.'
- **Remember:** it's '**some advice**', not '**some advices**'. We never add 's' to uncountable nouns.

We can make it countable with '**piece of**' -

- 'I'll give you **three pieces of** advice.'

You can also use the phrase '**a word of advice**'.

- '**A word of advice** - don't trust him.'
- This is a **set phrase** so we don't tend to say 'two words of advice.'

Another trick is to use a different word with a similar meaning to 'advice', for example -

- 'Let me give you **a tip** | **a pointer** | **a hint**.'
 - These three similar nouns are countable.

● **work** /wɜ:k/

Then we have **work**, as in things we have to do, often as part of our job, but maybe some other obligations. We can't say:

- 'I have **a** work to do.' ✗

We can say:

- 'I've got **some** | **loads** of work to do.'

You might sometimes see 'a' used with work in a **set phrase**. We can say, for example:

- 'I've got **a backlog of work**.'
 - This is a large amount of work that hasn't been done yet.

We can also use '**a stroke of work**' with a negative verb to mean no work at all:

- 'I haven't had **a stroke of work** for weeks.'

We don't usually say 'two works' (unless we're talking about books or art), so depending on the exact meaning, you can switch work for a different countable noun like '**task**' or '**job**.' For example:

- 'I've got to finish these two **tasks** by 5pm.'
- 'My little sister's got **a** summer **job** this year.'

● **furniture** /'fɜ:nɪtʃə/

Furniture is uncountable, so we can't say:

- 'I need **a** new furniture.' ✗

However, saying something like this works great:

- 'I need to get **a couple of items** | **pieces of** furniture for my new flat.'

And how can we make this first sentence negative? We normally use 'any' with

uncountable nouns in negative sentences:

- 'I don't need **any** new furniture.'

The same goes for questions:

- 'Do you need **any** new furniture?'

● information /ˌɪnfə'meɪʃn/

Information is another tricky one. Lots of my students say things like:

- 'I'd like some **informations**.' ❌

Remember, we can't add 's' to uncountable nouns.

- 'I'd like some **information**.' ✅

We can add '**a piece of**' to information.

- 'I need **a piece of** information.'

And we have a few other 'piece words' we can use: **snippet** and **nugget** – they have a similar meaning to 'a bit of'.

- 'Any **snippet of** information you can give me would be very helpful.'
 - **snippet** /'snɪpɪt/ a small piece of information
- 'My video lessons are full of valuable **nuggets of** information.'
 - **nugget** /'nʌɡɪt/ a small piece of information; an idea or a fact that is useful or valuable

● feedback /'fiːdbæk/

Next, we have **feedback**.

- 'My manager gave me **a** positive feedback on my last project.' ❌
- 'My manager gave me **some** | **a lot of** | **loads of** feedback.' ✅

● equipment /ɪ'kwɪpmənt/

Students often say things like:

- 'I bought **a** new equipment for my camera.' ❌

But **equipment** is uncountable. It refers to tools or gear as a whole.

- 'I bought **some** new equipment for my camera.' ✓
- 'The lab was **full of** high-tech equipment.' ✓

If you want to make it countable, try:

- '**a piece of** equipment'

● **luggage** /'lʌɡɪdʒ/

- 'I have two luggages.' ✗

Nope — **luggage** is also uncountable, even though it seems countable!

- 'Can you take **all of** my luggage?' ✓
- 'We left **some** luggage in the boot.' ✓

To refer to individual bags or suitcases:

- '**a piece of** luggage'
- '**three pieces of** luggage'

Or, to make it more specific:

- 'I just have **1 bag** | **suitcase**.'

● **accommodation** /əˌkɒmə'deɪʃn/

This one's is definitely a bit tricky. **Accommodation** is uncountable in British English.

'I need an accommodation in London.' ✗

- 'I need some accommodation in London.' ✓
- 'We're looking for student accommodation near the university.' ✓

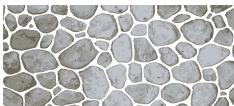
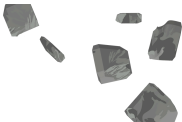
To refer to a specific option, use phrases like:

- 'a place to stay'
- 'a hotel room'

■ **Uncountable Nouns: Unit or Mass?**

Let's move on to some nouns that are sometimes used with **a** or **an** and sometimes not, depending on whether we imagine them as a large amount - a mass, or a single unit.

● stone vs a stone

stone (uncountable) the hard natural material	a stone (countable) a small rock
	
The house is made of stone. ✓	He threw stones into the river. ✓
The house is made of a stone/stones. ✗	I have a stone in my shoe. ✓

● chocolate vs chocolates

chocolate (uncountable) the sweet brown substance	chocolates (countable) individual sweets
	
My dad loves chocolate. ✓	Can I have a chocolate, please? ✓
My dad loves a chocolate. ✗	◦ a bar of chocolate ✓ ◦ a square of chocolate ✓

● hair vs a hair

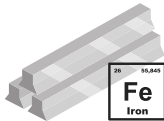
hair (uncountable) all the hair on your head	a hair (countable) one strand
	

She has long blonde hair. ✓	There's a hair in my soup! ✓
She has a long blonde hair. ✗	Why are there so many beard hairs in the sink? ✓

● paper vs a paper

paper (uncountable) the material	paper (countable) a newspaper or written report
	
The letter is printed on recycled paper. ✓	I read a research paper all about this! ✓
The letter is printed on a paper. ✗	She wrote a brilliant paper on climate change. ✓

● iron vs an iron

iron (uncountable) the metal	an iron (countable) a tool for smoothing clothes
	
This gate is made of iron. ✓	I need to buy a new iron. ✓
This gate is made of an iron. ✗	They must have an iron you can use. ✓

● glass vs a glass

glass (uncountable) the material (used in windows etc.)	a glass (countable) a container you drink from
	
- Be careful — there's broken glass on the floor. ✓ - There's a broken glass on the floor. ✗ (when referring to the material)	- Would you like a glass of water? ✓ - He dropped a glass and it smashed. ✓

■ Countable or Uncountable: Different Meanings

Ok, let's look now at words that can be countable or uncountable, depending on their meaning.

● time vs a time

time (uncountable) the general concept (seconds, minutes, hours, etc.)	a time (countable) a specific occasion something happened
Do you have time to help me? ✓	I've already failed my driving test 5 times! ✓

● exercise /'eksəsaɪz/

exercise (uncountable) physical activity	exercise (countable) a specific set or series of physical movements
I'm not a big fan of exercise. ✓	Our yoga teacher always does a few breathing exercises before we start moving on our mats. ✓

Exercise with the meaning of a set of questions is countable. For example:

- practice
 - listening
 - comprehension
- } **exercises**
- ‘Now it’s time to do your grammar **exercises**.’

● room /ru:m/ or /rʊm/

room (uncountable) space or capacity	room (countable) a part of a building (e.g. bedroom)
• Do you have room for one more person in the car? ✓	• We rented a room with a view of the lake. ✓

■ Nouns Always in the Plural

Some nouns in English are always written in the plural even when you're talking about just one item. These often refer to things that have two parts, like legs, arms or lenses.

- I need **a new trousers**. ✗
- I need **some new trousers**. ✓
- I bought **a new pair of trousers**. ✓

We can't use **a** or **an** directly with these nouns. To count them, we use “a pair of...” or “two pairs of...”

● Common Plural-Only Nouns

Clothes (with two legs)	Accessories & Instruments (with two parts)
trousers	sunglasses
jeans	goggles
shorts	binoculars

leggings	headphones
tights	tweezers
shorts	scissors

- I bought two pairs of **leggings**.
- Have you seen my **sunglasses**?
- You'll need **a** good **pair of scissors** for that.

Here are a few more 'forever plurals', some related to money and others that are just a bit random!

Money-Related	Random
earnings	likes / dislikes
savings	thanks
funds	congratulations
riches	surroundings
proceeds	leftovers

- The book tells the story of a quest for **riches**.
- He used his **savings** to buy a new laptop.
- Let's talk about our **likes** and **dislikes**.
- Please give her my **thanks** for all of her help today!
- We had **leftovers** for lunch today.

Collocations with The - Not A/An

Ok, here's our last category. Now, I'm not going to say we never use these words with **a** or **an**, but they are phrases that more frequently collocate with **'the'**.

I'd love to visit Greece in **the** future.

I've never had **the** flu.

I never shower at **the** gym.

I don't really listen to **the** radio.

If you'd like to practise what you've just learnt, click the link below for an interactive quiz designed to help you use these articles naturally!

BONUS

 [Click here to access the exercises!](#)



**JUST ONE MORE
THING BEFORE
YOU GO...**

You thought we were done with articles? Not quite! 🤖

We've talked a lot about when not to use **a** or **an**, but what about their equally sneaky cousin **the**? It deserves a moment in the spotlight too. In this next section, we'll look at when **the** is necessary, helpful or just quietly doing its job in the background.

Let's clear up the mystery of **the** once and for all...



EVERYTHING TO KNOW ABOUT 'THE'

Unsurprisingly, *the* is one of the most common words in the English language, and we use it all the time—see, I just used it three times in one sentence! This lesson will teach you everything you need to know about using 'the'.

HOW TO PRONOUNCE 'THE'

There are two ways to pronounce this word.

The first way is /ðə/, which is probably what you are more familiar with. We use the /ðə/ form when the following word starts with a consonant sound, for example:

/ðə/ = the book, the trailer

The second way to is /ði:/, which we use when the word that follows 'the' starts with a vowel sound:

/ði:/ = the intern, the entertainer

We also use /ði:/, for emphasis:

You are **THE** /ði:/ greatest!

It is also sometimes used while a speaker is thinking:

I will have the /ði:/... salmon!

HOW TO USE 'THE'

Let's look at some basic rules for using 'the'. We use it:

- to talk about a noun that has already been discussed and is now known to the reader or listener.

I just got a new sofa. *The* sofa is blue.

- to refer to a specific noun often used with a qualifier.

Don't put your phone on *the* broken table.

- to identify a unique noun when there is only one.

***The* sun is out today!**

Before getting into the specifics, it's important to know that we can use 'the' with **countable** and **uncountable nouns**.

Countable nouns are nouns that you can physically count, like **pencils** or **cars**. **Uncountable nouns** cannot be counted; things like **bread**, **coffee**, **soap**, **maths**, etc.

Let's look at 'the' a bit more in-depth to understand how to use it properly.

Use **the**:

before superlative adjectives and adverbs

We had **the best** time yesterday.

This has to be **the slowest** taxi in town.

with clauses and noun phrases introduced by 'only'

My aunt is **the only** person I trust.

Is this **the only** bowl you have?

with plural country names (typically ending in 's')

Have you been to **the Netherlands**?

The beaches in **the Bahamas** are incredible!

before country names that include 'republic', 'kingdom', 'union' or 'state'.

She is currently in **the Dominican Republic**.

Where should I go in **the United States**?

with ordinal numbers used as qualifiers

This is **the second** time she's been late.

You are **the fifth** doctor I've talked to about this.

before compass directions

I've never been to **the north** of France.

The south is quite warm this time of year.

to refer to geographical locationsShe was born in **the Middle East**.The best coffee grows near **the equator**.**to talk about certain geographical features, like:****oceans****the** Pacific Ocean**seas****the** Baltic Sea**rivers****the** Nile River**canals****the** Panama Canal**mountain ranges****the** Himalayas**deserts****the** Gobi Desert**forests****the** Amazon Rainforest**peninsulas****the** Iberian Peninsula**before famous buildings and well-known works of art**Did you go to Paris just to see **the Eiffel Tower**?I should have seen **the Mona Lisa**.**with adjectives that refer to specific groups of people**There have been recent calls to tax **the rich**.**The Spanish** settled here in 1695.**before family names, when referred to as a group****The McAllisters** moved last year.We had dinner with **the Smiths** last night.**with specific times**We will celebrate Leo's birthday on **the 25th**.Can you come in **the morning**?

to talk about time periods

My great-grandmother was born in
the 1800s.

I wish I had lived in **the 16th century.**

to say something about all the things referred to by a singular countable noun

The wolf is a dangerous animal.
(not a specific wolf, wolves in general)

My cousin plays **the violin.**
(not a specific violin, but the type of instrument)

before organisations

She works for **the US Postal Service.**

The World Health Organization just mentioned something about that.

when talking about hotels, restaurants and pubs

Don't stay at **the Ritz Carlton**; you should stay at **the Hilton!**

Let's have a few pints at **the Ship and Shovel.**

*We **don't** use 'the' when the name of an establishment starts with a name:

- We should head down to Froggy's Tavern. ✓
- We should head down to ~~the~~ Froggy's Tavern. ✗

with newspapers

Mandy told me to read this article from **the Guardian.**

We haven't read the review in **the Times** yet.

WHEN NOT TO USE 'THE'

Don't use the:

with general plural countable and uncountable nouns

She buys apples.

He is baking bread.

with most names, like:

names of people	Do you know John?
names of holidays	They have plans for Christmas and New Year's.

names of companies	I stopped using Twitter and Facebook when I got my Apple iPhone.
names of universities	When Scarlet finishes her undergrad at Oxford, she will transfer to Stanford.

*use 'the' when the university name starts with the word 'university', like:
My brother will be teaching at the University of Miami next year.

most country names EXCEPT FOR THE ONES MENTIONED EARLIER!	You should come to England! We're flying to Sri Lanka tomorrow.
names of cities, towns, states	Pollution is terrible in Los Angeles. My grandparents retired in Florida.
names of streets	Oleg's flat is on Lombard Street, right before St. George Lane.

The exception to this rule is **'the high street'**, which refers to the main street in a city or town that has many shops and restaurants:
The shop is on the high street.

names of lakes	We'll take the kids out to Windermere Lake at the weekend.
names of single mountains	She really wants to visit Mt Everest.
names of continents	This is my first time in Asia.

when talking about academic subjects

My daughter is having trouble with maths.

when discussing sports

I haven't played baseball since I was young.



when referring to languages or talking about someone's nationality

We've been learning Italian since April.

I just found out that I have Japanese ancestry.

The only exception is when you use the language as a qualifier:
I'm studying the Spanish language.

when we have a noun followed by a number

She and her husband will find you on platform 3.

with acronyms

We are still waiting to hear what NATO has to say.

*you will use 'the' with initialisms:
The FBI is investigating this situation.

There are also some common places and locations that typically do not require the use of an article. Learning these generally comes with practice, but here are few of the most common:

home	She is on her way home.
work	Can you pick me up from work today?
school, university (primary school, secondary school)	What time do you need to go to school? She's in her first year of university.
church	My friend and I met at church when we were 12.
hospital	Dad's in hospital at the moment.

KEEP IN MIND!

This only applies to British English. It is common to hear 'the' used before hospital in American English:

- Dad's in **the** hospital.

